PUBLIC REPORT · OCTOBER 2026

FROM HEARD TO “HERE’S WHAT CHANGED”

What students learned from district leaders about incident communication, the first “you said, we did” commitment, and what student voice should look like by June 2027.

Meeting with SPASD district leaders · Tuesday, October 20, 2026 · Prepared by Zackary Mark, Student Advocate

01 AT A GLANCE

Two SPASD directors met with student advocates and made one concrete commitment on the spot.

Commitment
District newsletters launching in November will go to all students, not just families.

Incident communication
What students hear depends on direct impact, age and severity. Some details can’t be shared by law.

Shared goal
By June 2027, students should be able to name something that changed because they spoke up.

What’s next
A wider, more representative survey on what good student voice looks and sounds like.

02 WHO WE MET AND WHY

The meeting brought student voice to the two district offices that shape how students hear from the district and whether every student has a way in.

NAME	ROLE
Dr. Michael D. Morgan Jr.	Director of Systemic Equity & Inclusion, SPASD
Marlita Bevenue	Director of Strategic Communications, SPASD
Zackary Mark	Student Advocate, SPASD Student Voice

The goal was to move student voice from being heard to being connected to action. We ran out of time before discussing a district student advisory council and equity questions, and plan to pick those up at a follow-up meeting.

03 HOW INCIDENT COMMUNICATION WORKS TODAY

Safety comes first, facts come second, and the message comes after that.

Dr. Morgan noted his answers reflected his own understanding, not a formal written district protocol.

WHAT DECIDES WHETHER STUDENTS ARE TOLD

Direct impact. An incident at one school is unlikely to be shared with students at a school it didn't affect.

Age of students. Messages are shaped to be age-appropriate.

Severity. More serious incidents get more communication and come from higher up.

THE STEPS, AS MS. BEVENUE DESCRIBED THEM

1. Make sure everyone is safe and accounted for.
2. Communications works with the principal and district leadership to confirm facts.
3. Decide who is affected, what each audience needs, and what's ready to share.
4. Her team prepares and reviews the message.
5. It comes from the principal, district leadership, or the superintendent, based on severity.
6. More information follows as it's confirmed.

WHAT CAN'T BE SHARED

WHAT	WHY
Names of students involved	Student privacy laws; many involve minors
Individual consequences and discipline	Protected student records
Grades and other student records	Protected student records
Personnel matters	Employee protections; directors often don't have the details either

Both directors stressed accuracy. Rumors on social media can spread faster than the district can verify facts, and sending wrong information would hurt trust more than a short delay.

04 WHAT STUDENTS ASKED FOR

Hear something reliable from the district, even when details can't be shared, because silence gets filled by rumors.

Short, factual messages
Even with no names, "a medical incident closed this area, here's what you need to know" takes five minutes and stops rumors.

Name the law
When something can't be shared because of a law, say which one. Many students will look it up.

Trust students' understanding
Students often feel information is held back because adults assume they won't get it. Most do.

"You said, we did" updates
Follow up on what actually happened, even if it's "nothing changed yet, here's what's happening."

Ms. Bevenue agreed students should hear directly from the district so they have a reliable source: clarify what's known, correct inaccurate information, and explain what's still being learned.

05 YOU SAID, WE DID: NEWSLETTERS TO ALL STUDENTS

Starting in November, district newsletters will go to every student, not only to families.

YOU SAID	THE DISTRICT SAID	THE COMMITMENT
In four years of high school, I had never received a district newsletter, and neither had many students I know.	Students were assumed to get family newsletters as part of the household. Dr. Morgan called it a process improvement, not intentional.	Ms. Bevenue will make sure newsletters go to all students when they launch in November with Superintendent Dr. Antoine Reed.

This is exactly the kind of change student voice is supposed to produce. We'll report back once the first newsletter goes out.

06 WHAT SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE BY JUNE 2027

Students should be able to name something that changed because they spoke up, and the goals should come from students themselves.

ASK STUDENTS FIRST

With about 8,500 students from 4K to 12th grade, Dr. Morgan said the first step is to survey students in age-appropriate ways on what student voice working well looks and sounds like. For the youngest learners, that may mean asking families.

SET GOALS WITH BENCHMARKS

Not every idea can happen by June. A realistic plan might commit to a few changes by June 2027, a few more by fall 2027, and keep going into 2028.

CLOSE THE LOOP

Ms. Bevenue said students should know where to bring an idea and hear back what happened, even if the answer is "we can't do that, and here's why." She encouraged students to be specific.

WHAT WOULD SHOW PROGRESS

A district-wide student survey, a district student advisory council with middle and high schoolers, and regular "you said, we did" updates.

07 WEIGHTED GRADES UPDATE

The student work group agreed weighted grades should start with the Class of 2031 in 2027–28.

Which classes: a 5.0 scale for capstone classes, tryout-based music courses, and classes earning industry certification or college credit.

Exceptions: college classes that don't transfer to UW schools, or that match electives or requirements the high school already offers.

Why freshmen: current students already chose classes under the old system, so switching now wouldn't be fair.

DATE	STEP
Week of Oct 26	Shared with the Student Senate
Nov 2, 4:45 PM	Student preview, Teaching & Learning Committee
Nov 9	Board of Education meeting
Late Nov	Expected final Board approval

08 NEXT STEPS AND WHAT'S STILL OPEN

One commitment in hand, two student tasks underway, and four asks still need an owner.

ITEM	OWNER	STATUS
Send district newsletters to all students	Ms. Bevenue	COMMITTED · NOV
Expand the climate survey to all high schools, all grade levels, and a racially and gender-diverse range of students	Zackary Mark	IN PROGRESS
Draft questions on what good student voice looks and sounds like	Zackary Mark	IN PROGRESS
Share the survey through district channels	Not yet named	OPEN
Name a staff partner for a pilot district student advisory council	Not yet named	OPEN
Set a recurring student–district check-in	Not yet named	OPEN
Publish one public "you said, we did" update this semester	Not yet named	OPEN

The survey changes come from Dr. Morgan's feedback that results should reflect diverse perspectives, not the same small group of involved students.

09 HOW WE GOT HERE

Ten months from one email to the Board to a district commitment.

JAN 13
Student Safety & Trust Framework sent to the Board

JAN 26
Act 95 students present at a public hearing

FEB
Weighted grades work group begins

MAR 2
Student advocacy meeting with leaders

APR
Principal interviews; Student Senate elected

AUG
Meetings with Dr. Reed, Dr. Turner, Mr. Clark

OCT 1
LGBTQIA+ protections confirmed in writing

OCT 20
First "you said, we did" commitment

> *"Yes I feel safe at school. Yes I would feel comfortable telling an adult. No adults do not listen."*
>
> A student, winter 2026 outreach. This is the gap this work exists to close.

SPASD STUDENT VOICE
BUILT TO LAST

GET INVOLVED

ADD YOUR VOICE

TAKE THE CLIMATE SURVEY

forms.gle/9ULwNASeJFceHkCy8

12 questions in English or Spanish, for students, families, staff and community members. Answers are shared only in aggregate.

WEBSITE

spasdstudentvoice.netlify.app

Past reports, letters, district replies and a questions form.

INSTAGRAM

@spasdstudentvoice

Updates, meeting recaps and survey reminders.

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Zackary Mark, Student Advocate

About this report. This is an independent, student-led report, not an official publication of the Sun Prairie Area School District. It is based on notes and an audio recording from the October 20, 2026 meeting, recorded with permission, and the student weighted grades work group meeting that morning. District statements are summarized, not quoted word for word, and Dr. Morgan's answers reflect his own understanding rather than formal district policy. Both directors were offered a chance to flag inaccuracies before publication.

Written in good faith to strengthen trust, communication and student voice. It is not intended to accuse or target any individual, and should be read as a constructive public report, not a legal claim.

Prepared by Zackary Mark · October 2026

STUDENT VOICE SHOULD MOVE BEYOND BEING HEARD TO BEING CONNECTED TO ACTION.